

# ICE crusher

SHIVA KESHAVAN,  
INDIA'S ONLY LUGE  
ATHELETE, SLIDES  
DOWN ICY TRACKS AT 88  
MILES AN HOUR ON A  
SLED WITH NO BRAKES

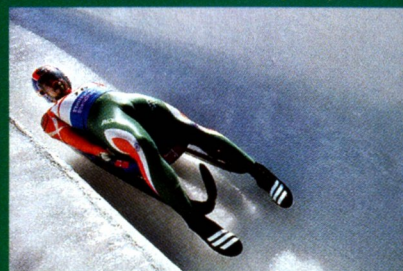
BY SHARMI GHOSH DASTIDAR

It's a glistening track of ice, angled and full of curves. Viewers lean over the railing, looking out on the super slippery track that resembles an ice cave. And then, one long blink, and they zip past—those men in tight speedsuits (custom-made to fit like a second skin) and helmets (with shatter-proof face shields) who hurtle down on their back on sleds at more than 100 kilometers (60 miles) per hour. The crowd gasps.

Welcome to luge, the fastest sport on ice and the ultimate sport for speed and control. And meet Shiva Keshavan, 27, the luge pilot who is the first Indian to win a

VIKRAM SHARMA

I am looking forward to the Winter Olympics. I want to change my Asian bronze medal to a gold. I know I can.



bronze medal at the Winter Asian Championship in 2008. He is a three-time Olympian and the only Indian to have qualified for the Olympic Winter Games in 2010.

Keshavan, son of an Italian mother and a South Indian father, was born and brought up in Vashist in Himachal Pradesh. In a predominantly hot country where winter sports are hardly in the news Keshavan, at the age of 10, was noticed by former world champion, Gunther Lemmerer, in a talent camp. "I was an adventurous kid and loved playing on ice. I participated in the camp and got to meet Gunther. He showed us videos and footages of the actual sport as it was played in foreign countries and I was hooked." The year after the boy got invited to the World Championships in Austria. "I witnessed the real action and how big luge was abroad. I wanted to be like those fast guys. Since then I have been honing myself to get better."

Keshavan, who once rejected an offer to become a member of the Italian luge team, is organising camps in India with the Indian Amateur Luge Association to scout for talented youngsters. Cheers to the athlete who is bringing glory to India in a tricky international sport. Kudos and luck is what we wish him. ■

